

Re-Onboarding

Has this ever happened to you? You boot up a new game of Skyrim (or any single player game for that matter), you're having a blast, you play for a few days, then you decide to take a break. Unfortunately, for whatever reason, that break ends up being rather long. Once you finally have some time to get back to the game you were playing... umm, what were you doing again? How did you even get here? Do you even remember how to play anymore? I don't know about you guys, but I've experienced this several times. Back in the day I wouldn't have minded starting over, but nowadays, with time being an issue that's not really an option. Heck, I've even dropped games midway after a break because I simply didn't have the time to start over.

Games usually have a sense of progression, a system to ease players into the game (the tutorial if you will), slowly introducing new mechanics to players as they progress through the game. Once you're through that part of the game, in the game's eyes you know how to play now. However, if you happen to stop playing at this point and return at a later date, there's no easing in; you're dropped straight into the deep end. This breaks immersion because you've no clue what's going on in terms of the plot, and it also affects your enjoyment of the gameplay because you've most probably forgotten most of the gameplay aside from the basics.

Every time I boot Skyrim up, even though I'm familiar enough with the gameplay at this point for that to not be an issue, I find that I'll start over from scratch. I don't remember where the previous character was storywise, what level it got to, how I spent my skill points back then, nothing. It just feels like less of an issue to start over.

So, what's the solution? Games could probably measure the amount of time we've been away from the game. So maybe after a certain point – say two weeks maybe? – games could



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reintroduce you to the game's mechanics and what you're capable of.

If you still remember everything then you're free to skip the whole thing and be on your way. Similarly, a recap of sorts, not unlike the kind we see in TV shows, to catch us up to the story so far. I feel like that would greatly improve the overall experience of playing RPGs, especially with worlds and stories becoming as massive as they are. What do you guys think? *